

■ By Stephen David

"I cannot forecast to you the action of Russia. It is a riddle, wrapped in a mystery, inside an enigma; but perhaps there is a key. That key is Russian national interest."

What Winston Churchill said in another context could well be said of H.D. Deve Gowda, the humble farmer-turned-chance-prime minister. Last week, the mysterious Gowda and his inscrutable family dragged politics in the country to a new low when, exactly seven days after submitting affidavits to Karnataka Governor Rameshwar Thakur promising unconditional support to the new BJP government of B.S. Yeddyurappa, Gowda's Janata Dal (S) pulled the plug on the saffron party's first-ever government in the south. The key to that bizarre decision is the Gowda family interest.

It used to be said, not always in jest, of Atal Bihari Vajpayee that he was able to function effectively as prime minister because as a bachelor, he did not have to deal with conflicting demands from pesky family members. While Gowda's 11-month stint as prime minister is best forgotten, his long political innings has always been dictated by the interests of his family. Just one example—in early 2006, when his son H.D. Kumaraswamy led the JD(S) out of the coalition government with the Congress, Gowda indulged in some theatrics before television crews to call it "the saddest day in my life" and even threatened to kill himself. Yet that grief turned to barely-concealed joy when Kumaraswamy joined hands with the much-hated BJP to form the government.

A similar family drama preceeded the fall of the Yeddyurappa government. Sources say, there were two key reasons: the first was that Gowda was determined to push his favourite son H.D. Revanna's candidature as the deputy chief minister under Yeddyurappa. Although BJP favoured Kumaraswamy because it found it easier to deal with him, it kept a low profile on the issue, hoping the matter would be sorted out within the family. In fact, six months ago, Gowda had sounded out Kumaraswamy about stepping down in favour of his brother, who Gowda had anointed as his heir apparent, having introduced him into politics at a time when Kumaraswamy was busy leading life as a film producer. Revanna was Gowda's pointsman and looked after their native Holenarsipur in Hassan district, but Kumaraswamy, who won the Assembly seat for the first time in the last elections and went on to become the state's youngest non-Congress chief minister at the age of 46, was in no mood to budge.

Having pledged support to BJP and after working overtime on a Sunday to secure affidavits of support, Gowda was determined to have his way and push for Revanna as his choice for the deputy chief minister's post. Assuming that his wish would be the party's command, Gowda did not even turn up at the JD(S) party meeting. But when he heard that the party legislators did not even consider

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Deve Gowda's lust for power sees the first BJP government in the south collapse barely after a week in

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certainty, the former prime minister's antics may well boomerang on him and his carefully crafted

